WEEK 3 · LESSON 13 OF 24 · HANDOUT

AI for Writing and Communication

Study time: **about 45 minutes** (reading, video and activity)

▶ **Watch:** https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=fezN-GtWobg — open the lesson online to watch inside the course.

🎓 **Go deeper:** CS50 Tech Talk with OpenAI: ChatGPT for Writers — https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=ZeTeHYHOtuw

Your goal in this lesson: Use AI to draft, improve, shorten, translate and adapt professional writing — emails, letters, reports and CVs — while keeping your own voice.

Where AI helps most with writing

- **Beating the blank page** — getting a first draft in seconds.
- **Polishing** — fixing grammar, making sentences clearer, removing repetition.
- **Adapting** — changing the tone for a manager, a client, a parent or a friend.
- **Shortening** — turning a long message into three lines a busy person will read.
- **Translating** — between English, French, Kinyarwanda and Swahili (always have a fluent speaker check important translations, especially in Kinyarwanda).

The draft–edit–own method

1. **Draft with AI** — give rough notes and clear instructions.
2. **Edit as yourself** — correct facts, remove anything you would never say, add personal details only you know.
3. **Own it** — read it aloud. If it does not sound like you, change it. You are the author.

Useful writing prompts

- *"Turn these rough notes into a clear, polite email to a client. Keep it under 150 words: [notes]"*
- *"Make this paragraph clearer and more professional, but keep my meaning and my simple style: [text]"*
- *"Rewrite this message for three audiences: my manager, a customer, and a WhatsApp group."*
- *"I need to say no to this request politely and suggest an alternative. Here is the situation: [details]"*
- *"Check this report for unclear sentences and grammar mistakes. List the problems first, then give the corrected version."*

CVs and cover letters

AI is very useful for job applications **if you stay honest**:

- Ask it to turn your duties into clear achievements: *"Rewrite these duties as achievement bullet points with action verbs. Do not invent numbers: [duties]"*.
- Ask it to compare your CV to a job advert: *"Which requirements in this advert does my CV show well, and which are missing?"*
- **Never** let AI invent qualifications, results or experience. Employers check — and dishonesty ends careers.

Common writing traps

- Generic, "robotic" phrases that make every message sound the same.
- Over-long answers — always set a word limit.
- Wrong cultural tone — check greetings and politeness fit your audience in Rwanda.
- Invented facts inside an otherwise good draft.

Remember this: Let AI draft and polish, then edit and own every word you send.

Name: _____ Date: _____

Activity

Task 1

Write rough notes for a real message you need to send (to a lecturer, client, colleague or employer).

Task 2

Use AI to draft it with a clear prompt (audience, tone, length).

Task 3

Edit the draft: mark in a different colour everything you changed and why.

Task 4

Ask AI to produce a version for a different audience and compare the two.

Self-check

Think about your answers here, then take the quiz online — it is marked instantly and explains every answer.

1. In the draft–edit–own method, what happens in the 'own' step?

   A. You read it, make it sound like you and take responsibility as the author
   B. AI sends the message for you
   C. You delete the draft
   D. You copy it without reading

2. Which is an honest way to use AI on your CV?

   A. Ask it to invent impressive numbers
   B. Ask it to add a degree you do not have
   C. Ask it to rewrite your real duties as clear achievement bullets without inventing facts
   D. Let it write fake references

3. Why should a fluent speaker check an important Kinyarwanda translation?

   A. Translations are always perfect
   B. AI tools have less Kinyarwanda training data and make more errors
   C. It is required by AI companies
   D. Kinyarwanda cannot be written

4. What is a simple way to stop AI answers from being too long?

   A. Write the prompt in capitals
   B. Ask twice
   C. Set a word or sentence limit
   D. Use more emojis

5. Which prompt best adapts one message for different readers?

   A. Rewrite this message for my manager, a customer and a WhatsApp group.
   B. Make it longer.
   C. Translate everything into code.
   D. Write something.

6. What is a common writing TRAP when using AI?

   A. Editing the draft
   B. Reading it aloud
   C. Sending generic, robotic text with invented facts
   D. Setting a word limit

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